

FIGHT TO THE FINISH
Sai (second from right), a student from Tamil Nadu who has joined a Ukrainian local militia

PAWAN KUMAR/AAJTAK

tents, was flattened by Russian artillery and missile strikes. "The strikes on Kharkiv are punitive. The city is being bombarded to break the morale of the Ukrainians so that we do not resist when the Russians attack Kyiv," says Tatanya Oleg, a school teacher in Kharkiv.

In Kyiv, a legion of the Georgian army is doing a training camp for civilians. With wooden rifles on their shoulders, residents, including teachers, gym instructors and bus drivers, are doing drills. They are being taught basic military tactics to assist the Ukrainian army.

Amongst the trainees is a young Indian student from Tamil Nadu, Sai, who is in Ukraine studying aerospace engineering. "I have been studying in Ukraine for the past 3 years. I have close friends here. This is my second home and it is under attack. When my Ukrainian classmates are fighting for their homes, how can I abandon them? So I decided to join them," says Sai.

Sai fears that he may be expelled from his college but says he has made up his mind to stand by his friends. And he isn't the only one. There are many foreign fighters, including mercenaries from Europe and the US, some of whom are veterans of the Afghanistan and Iraq operations. "I have operated in Afghanistan and have rich experience as a combat medic. I hope it will be of help to the Ukrainian forces," says William, who is training with the Georgian legion. Militia commanders say they are expecting mercenaries from Poland, US, Georgia, Australia and France to join the fight against Russia.

"The Ukraine army of 2022 is not the same that fought in the Donbas region in 2014. They have undergone extensive training with the NATO forces in the past eight years. Training, tactics and weapons are all NATO standard," says Kuldeep Kumar, an Indian businessman here who is married to an Ukrainian national. He says he will not leave despite the fears of a prolonged siege of Kyiv. "My wife is Ukrainian. My children are Ukrainian. They ask if India was being attacked, would I leave the country? Ukraine is their motherland. How can we leave?" he asks as the family shows us its stash of weapons including assault rifles.

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TATYANA OLEG
School teacher, Kharkiv

But not everybody wants to stay and fight. On the train from Mariopol to Kyiv, we meet Dasha, a young musician who was fleeing the intense shelling of Donetsk. "There is no point. This shelling, firing and war will not be over soon. I am a musician and music is not heard in the din of gunfire and shelling. I want to start afresh in Poland," she says.

The trains are full of people fleeing the war zone. Ukrainian men between 20 and 50 are not permitted to leave the country. They have been ordered to join the battle to protect the country. But given the vastly superior Russian forces, that's a task easier said than done. ■